

Chapter 1

Instructor's Manual

This chapter covers:

- The innateness of language
- Aspects of language upon which linguists agree
- The universality of language change
- The linguistic equality of spoken languages
- The difference between grammaticality and communicative effectiveness
- The differences between spoken and written language
- Language variation

Sample answers to the questions from the text and the website

From the textbook

1. Browse through *The Speech Accent Archive*. Listen to speech samples from places you know well, where you have lived. How does your own variety of English compare? Do the samples on the website strike you as representative? Consider submitting a sample of your own speech to add to the archive (under “how to use this site”).

Sample answer: As a lifetime resident of northern California, I found that the samples from other native English speakers in California were pretty representative of my own dialect, despite the fact that there are no samples from speakers from the far northern part of the state, where I was born. I think English 219, a sample from a female speaker born in Berkeley, CA, is most representative of my own dialect.

2. Pick one of the website resources provided above (but not the *Speech Accent Archive*) and report to the class on what it is, and how it might be of interest or use.

Sample Answer: Language Log is a blog written by linguists that addresses a range of language issues. It is relevant for any course using this book because its writers frequently address issues of standard language ideology, prescriptivism, the differences between speech and writing, and other interesting linguistic topics.

3. Ask five people you don't know well why it's wrong to say “I seen it yesterday when I got home.” Do not react to their response, and don't engage in conversation. Concentrate on taking notes. In class, compare the answers you got to those other students recorded. Similarities? Differences? Does gender or age make a difference? How does this exercise illustrate the *taxicab maxim*, if it does at all?

Sample Answer: Most participants answered with “It doesn't make any sense,” “It's ungrammatical,” or “Because it should be ‘saw,’ not ‘seen’.” This exercise demonstrates the

taxicab maxim because, while this sentence may be violating the prescriptive rules of the people who disapprove of the grammatical construction, it does not violate the laws of English (as evidenced by the fact that it is a comprehensible sentence rather than “word salad.”)

4. In his essay “Standard English a Myth? No!” Kilpatrick disputes the claim that all languages and language varieties are potentially equal, and uses this comparison to make his point: “And to assert that all languages and all dialects ‘have the same expressive potential’ is to assert that the ukulele ranks with the cello” (Kilpatrick 1999). Does this strike you as a valid comparison? Why or why not?

Sample Answer: This does not strike me as a valid comparison for his point. Languages are not instruments, and each language or language variety has evolved to suit the needs of its speakers (just as each instrument is well-suited to its role within a musical tradition, making the comparison of the inherent value of instruments another futile effort). It is also noteworthy that Kilpatrick chose to compare the cello to the ukulele with the implication that the instrument of European origin is of a higher value than an instrument associated with Hawaii. His comparison reflects dominant language ideologies connected to race, ethnicity, and national origin.

5. Milroy and Milroy (1999) state: “As writing skills are difficult, our educational systems have concentrated on inculcating a relatively high degree of literacy, with little attention paid to the nature of spoken language as an everyday social activity.” Can you conceive of ways that our schools might pay more attention to developing spoken language skills? What would the goals be?

Sample Answer: Schools do not need to teach students any spoken language skills at all since healthy children will fully acquire whatever languages are spoken in their community without intervention. However, schools could implement a spoken language program, which I would imagine would aim to train children to use SAE in their more formal speech as well as in their writing and/or participate in a wider range of registers than they may already use, such as those needed for professional phone calls, toasts, etc.

6. Galileo was the mathematician and astronomer who first observed that the earth revolves around the sun. This did not sit well with the Catholic Church, which taught that the earth was the center of the universe and everything revolved around it. They forced Galileo to recant his position, but afterward he is said to have mumbled (rebelliously) *Eppur' si muove*: And yet, it moves. How does this episode parallel the way linguists and people more generally think about language in the present day?

Sample Answer: This episode parallels the way people think about language because people in the present day (and in other times in history) are fiercely passionate about their language ideologies, and it is extremely difficult to convince people to give up – or even question – these dearly-held beliefs. In addition, like Galileo, linguists are a small minority in a very vocal majority that does not base its beliefs on scientific evidence.

7. Is FOXP2 evidence that supports Chomsky's innateness hypothesis?

Sample Answer: The discovery of FOXP2 does support Chomsky's innateness hypothesis because it provides evidence that there is at least some genetic basis for language development.

From the website

Listen to the samples of the language varieties spoken in Orange County, Chicago, South Boston, and Smith Island provided by the International Dialects of English Archive and The Speech Accent Archive.

1. In Chapter 1, the author states that these varieties, while very different, "are all equally efficient as languages, although they do not enjoy the same degree of respect (p. 9)." How do you think each of these dialects might be evaluated by speakers in your community? Which would be most respected and why? What does this reveal about language attitudes in your community?

Sample Answer: In my primarily middle- and working-class northern California community, I think that the California dialect from Orange County would be judged to be the least stigmatized variety, especially since it is quite similar to the variety spoken in my community. I would surmise that the northwestern Chicago dialect would be given the next most respect, followed by the Boston Southie dialect. I think that the dialect spoken on Smith Island would be given the least amount of respect. I hypothesize this hierarchy because I think my speech community favors western varieties of English over eastern or southern varieties, and would disprefer language varieties associated with the working class. Also, despite the fact that I live in a pretty rural area, I expect that many in this community would privilege urban varieties of English over rural ones.

"Woe is Us" – bad grammar permeates language (11/11/2005)

MSNBC Nightly News

http://www.msnbc.msn.com/id/10004296/ns/nightly_news/

2. How did this news clip frame the story on "bad grammar" and what was its main message? What linguistic examples did the story provide to support this message? Was the evidence they provided for the decline of English convincing? Why or why not?

Sample Answer: In this story, "bad grammar" is framed as a disease that threatens the English language, and the main message is that English is decaying. Examples of the decay of English include a general reference to language use online (with no specific examples), one 45-word sentence, the phrases "all intents and purposes," "at this point in time," and "awfully nice" and the use of the words *unbelievable*, *anxious*, and *irregardless*. This evidence is very unconvincing because the handful of words and phrases they provide as examples do not prevent communication from happening. On the basis of this limited and unpersuasive evidence, the report concludes that English is on the brink of destruction.

3. According to this clip, who or what has the authority to determine what is “good” and “bad” language?

Sample Answer: This clip suggests that news anchors have the authority to determine what is good and bad English, as do English teachers. One man featured in the clip is introduced as an authority on language, but the only qualification the reporter explicitly mentions is that he “was among the first to notice Americans butchering their language.” References are also made to the dictionary as the ultimate authority on language. An especially interesting moment is when anchor Brian Williams seems dismayed to report that the word *irregardless* was actually found in two dictionaries (despite reporter Roger O’Neil’s assertion that it cannot be found in dictionaries and is therefore not a word) and says, “it’s a word, just not a good one.” This comment suggests the dictionary’s power to legitimize words (or not), and the anchor’s power to assign value to words legitimated by the dictionary.

Suggested activities and discussion questions

1. Discuss the difference between descriptive and prescriptive grammar. Ask students to write down one prescriptive rule violation (or a prescriptive rule) that bothers them. Discuss these rules in small groups or as a class. Ask students to make an argument attacking or defending the “rule” or “violation.” Why do the students feel the way they do? Do any the prescriptive rule violations the class mentioned prevent communication?
2. Linguists agree that all living languages change. Ask the students to think of any ways that English – or any other language(s) they speak – is changing. For example, do their parents or grandparents speak differently than they do? Encourage brainstorming at every level if possible – phonological, morphological, syntactic, semantic, lexical, etc. What makes the speech of their generation unique? Discuss these changes. Do the students think these changes are bad, good, or neutral? Why do they feel the way they do?
3. Ask the students if they have ever been corrected on their grammar. How did that make them feel? If they have children now, or if they plan to have children in the future, do (or would) they correct their children on that same grammatical issue? Do (or would) they correct them on any language use? What do they think is most important to correct and why do they place importance where they do?
4. Review the differences between speaking and writing, and discuss some differences in grammatical construction. Have students experiment with speaking the way that they write for one day (or part of one day, or even one conversation!). Ask them to take careful notes on what the experience is like and report their reflections back to the class or in writing. What did they think about the experience? Was speaking as close to writing as possible more efficient or effective than speaking in their normal fashion?
5. To enhance discussion of this chapter, please visit the companion website and check out the audio and video clips available for use in your classroom.